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Politics - Homelessness part of legislative action this year

October 28, 2023 | Press-Enterprise, The (Riverside, CA)
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According to local 2023 Point in Time Counts, homelessness grew 9% in 2022 in Los Angeles County, 12% in Riverside County, and 26% in San Bernardino County. Orange County counts its unhoused homeless residents every other year, but the number of homeless people in Orange County shelters rose 12% in 2023. Here's some new laws targeting the homelessness:

Assembly Bill 42

About the bill: AB 42, sponsored by Assemblymember James Ramos, D-Highland, temporarily stops — until January 2027 — local governments from enforcing requirements to provide fire sprinklers in temporary sleeping cabins if other safety measures outlined in the bill are used.

Assembly Bill 349

About the bill: AB 349, sponsored by Ramos, allows local governments or nonprofits to rent disused property on the grounds of Patton State Hospital near Highland to provide homeless services.

Assembly Bill 531

About the bill: AB 531, the "Behavioral Health Infrastructure Bond Act of 2023," sponsored by Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin, D-Thousand Oaks, puts a ballot initiative on the March 5, 2024 primary ballot. Voters will be asked to approve a $6.38 billion general obligation bond, with the funds going to provide 11,540 new treatment beds and housing units for homeless Californians. It would also pay for more outpatient care, including mental health services for the homeless and counseling for young people. The bond also includes $1 billion set aside specifically for housing homeless veterans.

Assembly Bill 785

About the bill: AB 785, sponsored by Assemblymember Miguel Santiago, D-Los Angeles, creates exemptions to the California Environmental Quality Act in Los Angeles and Los Angeles County to allow homeless services to be built more quickly.

Assembly Bill 1377

About the bill: AB 1377, sponsored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, streamlines the process for getting homeless veterans into housing.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Yarbrough, B. (2023, October 28). Politics Homelessness part of legislative action this year *Press-Enterprise, The (Riverside, CA)*, p. 1. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/194FB3D7DAABC628.